The Relocate Raleigh Guide

A practical, family-first playbook for moving to the Triangle.

About This Guide

This is the guide we wish we'd had before we moved. No fluff, no tourism-board boosterism, no "top 10 reasons to love Raleigh" filler. Just the information you need to decide whether the Triangle is the right move for your family — and, if it is, how to execute it without learning every lesson the hard way.

You'll find:

- Honest comparisons between Raleigh and the expensive metros most transplants are leaving
- Neighborhood breakdowns written for families, not investors
- A scouting-trip itinerary that actually tells you what you need to know in 3–5 days
- The Wake County school system decoded (it's not like anywhere else)
- Financial realities — taxes, property tax, hidden costs
- Moving logistics, from cross-country movers to your first DMV trip
- The cultural infrastructure that makes the Triangle feel like home
- A seasonal survival guide for people moving from cooler, drier climates

Everything here reflects the Triangle as of 2026. Where things change fast — home prices, school boundaries, employer hybrid policies — we've noted the date so you know when to double-check.

> **A note on scope.** This guide is written for families relocating to the Triangle from anywhere in the U.S. Most of our readers are leaving higher-cost metros (Bay Area, Seattle, New York, Boston, DC, Chicago), and the tax and cost comparisons lean on those because that's where the arbitrage story is sharpest. If you're coming from somewhere else, the neighborhood, schools, and logistics chapters still apply — the "what you're trading" math just looks different. The calculator on relocateraleigh.com handles any of the 50 states.

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Chapter 1 — Is Raleigh Right For You?

The honest filter

Before we sell you on the Triangle, here's who it *isn't* a great fit for:

- People who need ocean or mountains out their back door. The coast is 2 hours. The mountains are 3–4. Both are drivable weekends; neither is a Tuesday afternoon.
- People allergic to humidity. July and August are real.
- People who want a walkable, transit-dependent lifestyle at NYC scale. Downtown Raleigh and parts of Durham are walkable. Most of the region isn't.
- People who want the exact same cultural density as a Tier-1 coastal metro. The Triangle has more than most outsiders realize, but less than what you're leaving.

If any of those are dealbreakers, save yourself the flight and stop here. If they're tradeoffs you can live with, keep reading.

The case for the move

The pitch in one line: **same tech career, half the housing cost, the best public school system in the South, and a thirty-something airport that gets you anywhere.**

The specifics, in numbers you can verify:

- **Tech family homes in the $600–850K range** in the suburbs with the strongest schools (Cary, Apex, Morrisville, Holly Springs), per Redfin March 2026 snapshots. See Chapter 2 for the breakdown.
- **North Carolina's flat 3.99% income tax**, lower than California (top 13.3%), New York, Massachusetts (5%), and Illinois (4.95%); higher than Washington's no-wage-tax regime. Details in Chapter 5.
- **Wake County Public Schools**, consistently one of the highest-rated large public systems in the Southeast, with 10-out-of-10 schools clustered in west Cary, Morrisville, and Apex.
- **RDU International** with nonstop service to most major U.S. business hubs plus London, Paris, and a growing list of international destinations.

The live calculator on this site does the interactive comparison against the metro you're leaving. Use it, then come back here.

The tech job reality

The Triangle's 2026 job market is not dominated by a single hyperscaler. It's a broad mix of enterprise infrastructure, platform software, analytics, and financial technology employers, most of them hiring on **hybrid** rather than fully remote terms. A snapshot of who's hiring and how:

- **Cisco** — clearly active in RTP, unusually transparent about hybrid posture in listings. Dominant role families: cloud and platform engineering, SDET, AI security, compliance, sales engineering. Local norm is hybrid, not fully remote.
- **Red Hat** — still one of the region's deepest software employers, and more remote-flexible than its enterprise peers. Strong fit for Linux, Kubernetes, cloud-native, and platform engineers.
- **IBM** — thousands of hybrid postings, relatively few remote-only. RTP demand skews to software development on AI and hybrid-cloud products, Ceph and OpenShift support, and hardware-brand field roles.
- **Apple** — hiring now in leased Cary space while the permanent RTP campus remains delayed (state extended the timeline in late 2025). Current NC listings include iOS, Apple Pay, Creator Studio, and AI/ML roles, all local-office qualified.
- **Epic Games** — a genuine anchor in Cary but more office-centric than most. Engine programming, UI engineering, analytics, anti-cheat, ML research. Remote flexibility is limited.
- **Google Fiber** — smaller footprint than the others. Mostly network operations, field ops, and broadband sales — not a major generalist software employer here.
- **Fidelity** and **SAS** — both hire broadly across tech and non-tech roles with structured hybrid arrangements. Fidelity is one of the stronger "both spouses can find something" employers in the region.
- **Pendo** — still hiring in Raleigh but more selectively than in peak years, concentrated now in commercial sales, finance, and revenue ops.

On the scale-up lane, fragmented but real. Relay, Levitate, Teamworks, and Bandwidth all had double-digit open roles in April 2026. Less an automatic landing zone than a targeted search.

The 2026 takeaway: the Triangle is deeper for infrastructure, platform, security, architecture, customer-facing technical work, and enterprise sales than it is for pure "work from anywhere" consumer tech. If you need fully remote, verify the role before you move — don't assume the label.

The trailing-spouse question

Most tech families moving here have one partner with a remote or hybrid tech role and one partner who needs local work. The good news: the Triangle's non-tech economy is deep, and **healthcare is the single strongest absorption market** for a trailing spouse.

- **Duke Health**, **UNC Health**, and **WakeMed** — the three major health systems. Duke and UNC both maintain dedicated remote-work pages and hire broadly in clinical care, allied health, IT, analytics, and administrative roles. WakeMed is more on-site and clinical in practice.
- **RTI International** — research-and-evaluation institute in RTP. Smaller volume than healthcare but unusually broad across public policy, epidemiology, biostatistics, survey research, international development, and operations.
- **Financial services** — the backup plan after healthcare. **Fidelity** (covered above), **First Citizens Bank** (Raleigh HQ, hybrid and remote NC roles), **MetLife** (large Cary office with 40+ open tech and non-tech positions), and **Truist** (branch banking, cybersecurity, IT business analysis, audit).

If your trailing partner works in clinical care, administration, revenue cycle, PMO, IT, analytics, patient-access ops, public policy, research, finance, or banking operations, the Triangle absorbs them well. Sectors that are harder to land in: entertainment, media, high-end hospitality, and deep startup ecosystems of the Bay Area / NYC flavor.

Chapter 2 — Neighborhood Playbook

Every neighborhood chapter answers the same six questions, so you can compare apples to apples:

1. **Who lives here?** (general character, not demographic targeting)
2. **What does a 4BR family home cost?**
3. **What's the commute to RTP?**
4. **What schools are assigned?**
5. **What's it like on a Saturday?**
6. **Who should skip it?**

Quick-orientation map

The Triangle is really three cities plus a handful of suburbs wrapped around Research Triangle Park in the middle. From the outside in:

- **Raleigh** — the state capital. Has a downtown, but most of "Raleigh" is sprawling neighborhoods inside and outside the 540 beltway.
- **Durham** — smaller, artsier, home to Duke. Southern Durham blends into RTP.
- **Chapel Hill** — college town, home to UNC. Small, expensive, academically intense.
- **Cary / Apex / Morrisville** — the "western suburbs." Tech-family heavy, great schools, newer housing.
- **Holly Springs / Fuquay-Varina / Garner** — southern suburbs. Cheaper, more space, longer commutes.
- **Wake Forest / North Raleigh** — northern suburbs. Established, family-oriented.

A note on schools below. Wake County assigns base schools by address and can adjust assignments year to year. The school ratings and patterns we cite are *representative* of popular family zones in each neighborhood — not guarantees. Always verify a specific address against the WCPSS, CHCCS, or DPS lookup before you sign anything. Ratings referenced are GreatSchools out of 10 as of early 2026.

Cary

Character: family-oriented, school-driven, high-demand. The Triangle's most obvious landing zone for tech families.

Median sale price was about **$600K** (Redfin, March 2026). A realistic 4BR budget is **$600K–$1.1M**, with the top end concentrated in west Cary and newer school zones. Rush-hour to central RTP runs **20–35 minutes** from most addresses; farther west can slide into the high 30s. Representative west-Cary school patterns: **Green Hope Elementary 9, Davis Drive Middle 10, Green Hope High 10**; other zones feed **White Oak Elementary 10, Mills Park Middle 10, Green Level High 10**. Car-dependent (Walk Score 28) with a strong greenway network.

Pros: schools, parks, RTP access. **Cons:** price compression in top school zones; "Cary" means very different things once you go far west.

Apex

Character: family-first, newer construction, polished suburban — with a small historic downtown.

Median was about **$630K** (Redfin, March 2026). Workable 4BR band: **$550K–$850K**, with newer Apex Friendship and southern Apex pushing the top. Rush-hour to RTP is **25–45 minutes**, with NC-540 narrowing the gap (and adding tolls). Representative school patterns: **Olive Chapel Elementary**

9, Lufkin Road Middle 10, Apex Friendship High 9; **Salem Middle 10** and **Oakview Elementary 9** are also common cross-shops. Walk Score 26.

Pros: strong schools, attractive newer subdivisions, charming downtown. **Cons:** longer RTP commute than Cary/Morrisville; top school-adjacent zones escalate fast.

Morrisville

Character: tech-worker-heavy, practical, globally connected — closest to RTP and the airport.

Median was about **$576K** (Redfin, March 2026), with townhomes lower and detached homes in Parkside/Panther Creek-adjacent areas higher. 4BR band: **$500K–$800K**. The commute story is the headline — **10–25 minutes** to central RTP from many addresses, easily the best in the region. Representative school patterns: **Cedar Fork Elementary 9, West Cary Middle 10, Panther Creek High 10**; or **Alston Ridge Elementary 9, Alston Ridge Middle 10, Panther Creek High 10**. Walk Score 27.

Pros: commute efficiency, strong schools, airport access. **Cons:** more utilitarian feel; less of a traditional "downtown suburb" identity than Cary or Apex.

Holly Springs

Character: young-family suburban, newer construction, amenity-focused.

Median was about **$613K** (Redfin, March 2026); still one of the more competitive family-suburb pockets. 4BR band: **$575K–$850K**, with golf-course and newer-home communities above. Rush-hour to RTP: **25–40 minutes**, with the lower end realistic if you're near NC-540 (and paying tolls). Representative school patterns: **Oakview Elementary 9, Apex Friendship Middle 10, Holly Springs High 9** or **Holly Ridge Middle 9, Apex Friendship High 9**. Walk Score 19 — the least walkable of the major family suburbs here.

Pros: newer homes, parks, strong local identity. **Cons:** weak walkability; commute is route-sensitive in ways the drive-time map doesn't show.

Wake Forest

Character: established, more small-town feel, more house for the money.

Median was about **$454K** (Redfin, March 2026) — the cheapest major family market on this list. 4BR band: **$450K–$750K**, with Heritage-area homes commonly in the low-to-mid $500s. The tradeoff is commute: plan **35–55 minutes** to RTP, and the variance is higher than west-Wake because the trip leans on I-540. Representative patterns in Heritage: **Heritage Elementary 9, Heritage Middle 9, Heritage High 7**. Walk Score 20.

Pros: affordability, space, established character. **Cons:** commute friction to RTP; slightly weaker high-school ratings than west-Wake alternatives.

North Raleigh (inside 540)

Character: established, mixed-age, convenience-oriented. Closer to downtown Raleigh than the western suburbs.

Hard to summarize with one number — "inside 540" spans everything from North Hills to older Falls of Neuse neighborhoods. North Hills itself was around **$575K** median, but a realistic 4BR budget across desirable inside-540 pockets is **$650K–$1.25M**. Rush-hour to RTP: **25–45 minutes**, with worse return trips when I-540 or I-40 back up. School ratings vary: representative patterns around Midtown often show **Brooks or Green Elementary ~6, Carroll Middle ~5, Sanderson High ~6**. Walkability is low-to-moderate overall but meaningfully better in North Hills/Midtown.

Pros: centrality, mature trees, easier access to both RTP and downtown. **Cons:** more school-rating variability than western suburbs; uneven house-by-house value.

Durham — Southpoint and Woodcroft

Character: mixed-age, practical, one of the better value-plus-commute compromises in the region.

Woodcroft's median was about **$435K** (Homes.com, early 2026); Southpoint's single-family median was **mid-$500Ks to mid-$600Ks** depending on the cut. 4BR band: **$450K–$750K**. Rush-hour to RTP is **15–25 minutes** — a major selling point. Representative school patterns vary: **Southwest Elementary 9** or **Hope Valley Elementary 5**, **Sherwood Githens Middle 8**, **Jordan High 4**. Woodcroft's trail network is genuinely useful but most errands are still car-based.

Pros: RTP access, broader price spectrum than west Wake. **Cons:** more school-rating variability; less of the polished "master-planned suburb" feel.

Chapel Hill

Character: college-town, highly educated, family-heavy without feeling purely suburban.

Citywide median was about **$503K** (Redfin, March 2026), but that understates what families actually shop. For detached 4BR homes, plan **$650K–$1.2M**, with established east-Chapel-Hill and Meadowmont-adjacent inventory in the middle of that spread. Rush-hour to RTP: **25–40 minutes**. Representative school patterns: **Rashkis Elementary 8, Grey Culbreth Middle 5, East Chapel Hill High 9**; or **Estes Hills Elementary 8, Guy Phillips Middle 8, East Chapel Hill High 9**. Walk Score 34 and Transit Score 37 — highest in the region.

Pros: civic feel, schools, university-town amenities. **Cons:** price; older-housing maintenance; commute is good but not Cary/Morrisville short.

Downtown Raleigh

Character: urban, a mix of young professionals and established in-town neighborhoods. The smallest inventory of standard 4BR family houses on this list.

Redfin's downtown neighborhood figure sat in the **high $300Ks**, but that mixes condos with a very thin pool of true family houses. For a 4BR detached in or near the core — Oakwood, Boylan Heights, adjacent historic blocks — plan **$800K–$1.7M+**. Rush-hour to RTP: **25–40 minutes**, and it can feel longer because the route is congestion-sensitive. Representative school patterns for close-in listings: **Wiley Elementary 5, Oberlin Middle 6, Broughton High 7**. Walkability is the region's strongest in Glenwood South, Warehouse District, Boylan, and Seaboard blocks.

Pros: genuine urban lifestyle, in-town access. **Cons:** detached-home scarcity and cost; weaker fit if RTP commute is your top priority.

The comparison matrix

Neighborhood	Median (Mar 2026)	4BR band	RTP commute	Walk Score	In one word
Morrisville	$576K	$500K–$800K	10–25 min	27	Efficient
Durham (Southpoint/Woodcroft)	$435–600K	$450K–$750K	15–25 min	—	Value
Cary	$600K	$600K–$1.1M	20–35 min	28	Polished
Apex	$630K	$550K–$850K	25–45 min	26	Newer
Chapel Hill	$503K*	$650K–$1.2M	25–40 min	34	Academic
Holly Springs	$613K	$575K–$850K	25–40 min	19	Young-family
North Raleigh	~$575K (NH)	$650K–$1.25M	25–45 min	Low-mod	Established
Downtown Raleigh	high $300Ks*	$800K–$1.7M+	25–40 min	High (core)	Urban
Wake Forest	$454K	$450K–$750K	35–55 min	20	Spacious

*Citywide median understates typical 4BR family-house price — use the band instead. Sources: Redfin and Homes.com, March 2026 snapshots.

Chapter 3 — The Scouting Trip

You get one, maybe two trips before you decide. Don't waste them.

Before you book

- **Don't come in late March through April.** Pollen season is real and you'll form a negative impression that doesn't reflect the other eleven months.
- **Do come on a weekday.** You need to experience the RTP commute at rush hour. A Saturday visit tells you nothing about the Tuesday you'll actually live.
- **Fly into RDU.** Rent a car. There is no "get around by transit" version of this trip.

Before you arrive

Pick three or four candidate addresses and run each through the WCPSS base-school lookup, the DPS school locator, and the CHCCS assignment maps as applicable. During the trip, use DriveNC for real traffic data rather than trusting the GPS free-flow estimate.

The 3-day itinerary (for decisive families)

Treat this as a **life simulation**, not a highlights reel.

Day 1 — Cary, Morrisville, RTP. Drive a west-Wake loop through newer Cary and Morrisville neighborhoods. Do one **weekday peak-hour drive into RTP** using the exact route you'd use from your shortlist address. Midday stop at H Mart Cary or Grand Asia — not a polished brunch. Late afternoon at William B. Umstead State Park via Reedy Creek or Crabtree Creek to test how close real green space feels. If you still have energy, end at Boxyard RTP or Frontier to see whether RTP feels sterile or mixed-use.

Day 2 — Raleigh and North Raleigh. Midtown, North Hills-adjacent streets, and one quieter North Raleigh area mapping to your candidate base schools. **Visit the actual elementary and middle/high schools** tied to your addresses. Midday: test grocery and errand convenience. Finish with a deliberate school-pickup-hour drive on a major arterial, then a neighborhood dinner. You're learning whether daily circulation feels easy or car-heavy.

Day 3 — Durham and (if relevant) Chapel Hill. Use Southpoint as the Durham suburban anchor, then contrast with an older in-town neighborhood and downtown Durham's restaurant district. Market stop at Li Ming's or Compare Foods. Then choose: a late-afternoon visit to Jordan Lake State Recreation Area, or an evening devoted to Durham's food scene. If Chapel Hill/Carrboro is a contender, physically drive Southern Village, Meadowmont, downtown Chapel Hill, and Carrboro before leaving.

The 5-day itinerary (for families who want certainty)

The extra two days buy repetition and recovery time — the things that actually matter for a family decision.

Days 1–3 — same as above.

Day 4 — Second pass at the leading county, or Chapel Hill/Carrboro. Visit assigned schools for your top address. Walk one town center in daylight. Do one family-recreation block — Jordan Lake if water-and-weekend scale matters, Umstead if "quick nature after work" matters more.

Day 5 — Verification day. Not sightseeing. Redo your favorite commute in peak traffic. Shop at the store you'd actually use. Sit in the park you'd actually revisit. If possible, spend a few **working hours at Frontier, Raleigh Founded, American Underground, or Junction** — see Chapter 7 — and attend one evening meetup. By the end of day 5, most families stop asking "is the Triangle nice?" and start asking "which version of Triangle life fits us?" That's the question that actually predicts a good move.

What not to waste time on

- Model homes in brand-new subdivisions 40 minutes from RTP. The commute will kill you.
- The State Fairgrounds unless it's October.
- Trying to "see all of Durham" or "all of Raleigh." Pick two neighborhoods per day, max.

Chapter 4 — Schools Deep Dive

This is the chapter transplants most frequently wish they'd read first.

Wake County is not like where you came from

Most U.S. school districts work on a simple rule: you live in a zone, your kid goes to that school. Wake County Public Schools (WCPSS) doesn't work that way.

WCPSS layers three things on top of each other:

1. **Base school by address.** The district's address lookup tool tells you the assigned base school, calendar (traditional vs. year-round), and transportation eligibility for a given address.
2. **Choice system.** Families can apply to magnet schools, year-round schools, and early colleges. Selection is *not* first-come, first-served. Selected students are automatically assigned; waitlisted students stay in the pool for their first choice. Magnet and year-round results are **not appealable**.
3. **Annual enrollment planning.** WCPSS rebalances assignments every year to handle growth, new schools, and capped programs. Your neighbor's kid and yours could end up at different schools

next year.

The **magnet system** features specialized themes — STEM, leadership, arts, global studies — and requires you to first enroll in WCPSS (to get a student ID) before applying during the choice window.

The **year-round option** isn't just a calendar philosophy. WCPSS uses a four-track model that lets year-round schools serve about **25% more students** than traditional-calendar schools, which is also how the district manages growth in fast-expanding areas. Track assignments (which quarter your kid is "off") aren't guaranteed even if you list preferences.

Key dates for 2026–27 enrollment

From WCPSS's posted calendar:

- **October 15, 2025** — kindergarten and pre-registration opened; main choice window for magnet/year-round opened
- **December 15–17, 2025** — initial base-school assignment notices sent
- **January 22, 2026** — main choice window closed
- **February 19, 2026** — magnet/year-round results released
- **March 2–13, 2026** — main transfer window

For families moving in after the main windows close: new families may request a magnet or year-round option **within 10 days of enrolling**, though approval isn't guaranteed. There's typically a second-round magnet reopen in March for newly eligible families.

The timing trap

The single most expensive mistake transplants make: **assuming the base school you looked up in June is the one your kid will attend in August.** WCPSS doesn't publish a single "address-lock" date the way some private admissions offices do, but base assignment is always tied to current residence, and the district can revise assignments through its annual enrollment plan.

The safest move: **verify the exact address with WCPSS Student Assignment before you go under contract, and again before you submit enrollment paperwork.** Don't rely on a real-estate listing's "assigned school" field — verify directly.

Durham and Chapel Hill public schools

Chapel Hill-Carrboro City Schools (CHCCS) is more conventional than Wake: new students are assigned to the school zoned for their home address. The 2026–27 new-student registration opens **May 15, 2026**. CHCCS also runs dual-language lottery options including Mandarin and Spanish pathways for rising kindergarten students — worth flagging if you want heritage-language immersion inside the public system.

Durham Public Schools (DPS) sits between the two. The 2026–27 lottery window ran **January 5 to January 30, 2026**, and DPS began expanding student-assignment flexibility at the middle and high school levels starting in 2025–26. If you're buying in south Durham, verify the assigned schools twice — once with the current lookup and once with your realtor confirming no pending boundary changes.

Private options

Current tuition, from the schools' own websites:

- Cary Academy — 2026–27: $34,300 (middle school), $35,700 (upper school). Add a $1,500 dining fee and a $3,000 new-student fee.
- Ravenscroft (Raleigh) — current 2025–26 tuition: $32,350 (grades 6–8), $33,115 (grades 9–12).
- Triangle Day School (Durham) — 2026–27: $17,420 (TK/K), $19,185 (grades 1–5), $21,730 (grades 6–8). Plus additional listed fees. The price gap matters less than the model fit: Triangle Day is TK–8 only, while Cary Academy and Ravenscroft are K–12.

Other names commonly cross-shopped: Durham Academy, St. David's (Raleigh), Carolina Friends School (Durham). Verify current-year tuition directly on each school's site.

> **Charter schools** — we aren't covering individual charter options in depth in this edition because lottery mechanics, transportation, and program fit vary too much to generalize. If you're charter-shopping, start with Raleigh Charter High School, Woods Charter School (Chapel Hill area), and the school-by-school lottery pages on the NC Department of Public Instruction charter portal.

Heritage language and cultural education

The Triangle has a large international population, and that's reflected in the weekend schools and after-school language programs available. CHCCS's dual-language pathway (mentioned above) offers Mandarin and Spanish inside the public system. On the weekend-supplemental side, durable programs include:

- **Cary Chinese School** — Saturday Mandarin and activity classes
- **Japanese Language School of Raleigh** — Saturday supplemental since 1982
- **Triangle Korean School** — active in Raleigh
- **Triangle Lebanese-American Center** — Saturday Arabic youth classes in Raleigh
- **Chinmaya Mission RDU** — Sunday Hindi classes in Cary
- **Al-Furqan School** — weekend Islamic school

Enrollment timing shifts year to year; check each program directly before you plan around it.

Chapter 5 — The Money Chapter

The top-line tax swap

North Carolina's 2026 individual income tax rate is a flat 3.99%, per the North Carolina Department of Revenue. How it compares to common feeder states:

Leaving from	Their top state rate	Your NC rate	Typical direction
California	13.3% (top marginal)	3.99%	Large win, especially on high incomes
New York (incl. NYC)	~10.9% state + NYC resident tax	3.99%	Large win (you also drop NYC city tax)
Massachusetts	5% + millionaire surtax over threshold	3.99%	Modest win
Illinois	4.95% flat	3.99%	Small win
Washington	0% wage tax	3.99%	**Loss** on income — WA has no broad wage tax

Washington is the outlier. WA taxes capital gains and enacted a separate high-income tax in 2026 that's scheduled to start in 2028. For a W-2 earner coming from WA, you'll usually see a state income-tax *increase* moving to NC unless the housing-cost delta offsets it (which, in most Triangle-to-Seattle comparisons, it does).

Property tax reality check

North Carolina has no state property tax. Counties and municipalities stack their own rates. The Tax Foundation puts NC's average effective property tax at about **0.66%** of owner-occupied value — moderate, not ultra-cheap.

What you'll actually pay in the Triangle (FY 2025–26 rates, per $100 of assessed value):

Location	Combined rate	Notes
Wake County base	$0.5171	County only
Raleigh (in Wake)	**$0.8721**	Wake + Raleigh $0.3550
Cary (in Wake)	**$0.8571**	Wake + Cary municipal
Durham County base	$0.5542	County only
Durham (city, in Durham County)	**$0.9913**	County + city
Chapel Hill (in Durham County)	**$1.0542**	Highest in the matrix
Orange County base	$0.6383	County only
Johnston County base	$0.52	Plus fire district + municipal
Chatham County base	$0.60	Pittsboro adds ~$0.44 on top

So on an $800K home in Cary: about **$6,857/year** in property tax. Same home in Raleigh: **$6,977**. Same home in Chapel Hill (Durham-County portion): **$8,434**. The differences are real but not catastrophic — price the specific address, not the county.

The transplant surprise: vehicle taxation

This is the part of the move budget West Coast and Northeast households most consistently under-model. North Carolina charges:

- **A one-time 3% highway-use tax** when a vehicle title is transferred. On a $45K SUV, that's **$1,350** at registration.
- **Annual vehicle property tax**, collected at the same time as registration renewal via Tag & Tax Together. Covers the *upcoming* registration year. Typical annual bill on a $40K SUV: **$300–$600** depending on county.
- **Local municipal vehicle fees**, on top: Raleigh and Cary each charge **$30/year**, Durham (Wake-County portion) **$15/year**, per each municipality's current fee schedule.

None of these are large individually. Collectively, they add up to real money, and most transplants don't discover them until the first renewal notice.

Sales tax

NC state rate is **4.75%**. Counties add local and transit rates; Durham County's combined rate is currently **7.5%**. Compared to feeder states: below California (7.25% state base), Washington (6.5%), Massachusetts and Illinois (6.25% each); above New York's 4% state base.

Home-buying timeline from a high-COL market

The order of operations when you're selling a $1.8M house in the Bay Area to buy an $850K house in Cary is not obvious. Common paths:

- **Sell first, rent here for 6–12 months, then buy.** Safer, lets you neighborhood-shop in person. Best option if school assignment matters and you haven't locked an address.
- **Bridge loan / HELOC against current home.** Faster, more expensive, more risk. Works when timing alignment is tight.
- **Contingent offer.** Usually not competitive in either market — see current conditions below.

Current market conditions (early 2026). Per Redfin, March 2026 days-on-market:

- Holly Springs: 24 days — "very competitive," homes receiving ~2 offers on average
- Morrisville: 31 days — somewhat competitive
- Apex: 45 days — somewhat competitive
- Wake Forest: 57 days
- Chapel Hill: 61 days

The market is **looser than the 2021–22 frenzy but not broadly balanced**. Desirable homes in strong commute-plus-school pockets still attract multiple offers; weaker houses sit. Inspection contingencies are realistic, but a pure contingent offer (contingent on selling your current house) is a weak position in Holly Springs/Morrisville/west Cary. Better odds with a bridge loan or a rent-first strategy.

Hidden costs nobody mentions

- **HOA fees** — common in newer neighborhoods. Range $200–$1,200+ per year; resort-style communities can go higher.
- **Summer HVAC electricity bills** — plan for $250–$400+/month July through September on a typical family home.
- **Annual vehicle safety inspection** — cheap (~$30) but required before registration renewal; easy to forget.
- **Lawn care** — most family homes have lawns, most HOAs have standards. Budget $80–$200/month for service or invest in equipment.
- **Humidity-related home maintenance** — crawlspace dehumidification, HVAC capacity, mold inspection. Check all three before you buy an older home.

Chapter 6 — Logistics and the First 90 Days

Choosing a moving approach

Three tiers, ordered most-to-least expensive. The budget numbers below are 2026 planning ranges from MoveBuddha, American Van Lines, and national PODS pricing data — treat them as planning figures, not binding quotes.

Tier 1 — Full-service national mover. They pack, load, drive, unload, unpack. Most expensive, least work. Safest mainstream options: **United Van Lines**, **Mayflower**, **Allied Van Lines** — all federally licensed for interstate moves, all can bundle packing, storage, and car shipping.

- **3BR Seattle → Raleigh**: ~$6,000–$11,500
- **3BR Bay Area → Raleigh**: ~$4,500–$9,500 (San Jose/Peninsula ZIPs and peak-summer timing push toward the upper half)

Tier 2 — Container / POD. You pack, they deliver, store, and drive. Middle cost, middle effort. Main national options: **PODS**, **1-800-PACK-RAT**, **U-Pack ReloCube**.

- **3BR Bay Area → Raleigh**: ~$2,500–$5,200 (MoveBuddha)
- **3BR Seattle → Raleigh**: plan ~$3,000–$6,000, higher with storage or peak timing

Tier 3 — DIY truck. Cheapest on the sticker, most work. **Penske** (unlimited miles on one-way rentals), **U-Haul**, **Budget**. The rental price is only part of the bill.

- Advertised 3BR Bay → Raleigh truck rental: ~$1,600–$3,800
- Realistic all-in (fuel, hotels, tolls, hired loading help): **mid-$3,000s to mid-$6,000s+**

For a family with a full household, Tier 2 is usually the sweet spot. Tier 1 is worth it if both spouses are working through the move week; Tier 3 makes sense mostly for childless or minimal-furniture moves.

Shipping the car

Usually worth pricing separately, even if a full-service mover can bundle it. Strong national brands: **Sherpa Auto Transport**, **Montway**, **RoadRunner Auto Transport**. All offer transparent public pricing.

- **Open transport, Seattle → Raleigh**: ~$1,500–$2,450
- **Open transport, California → Raleigh**: ~$1,150–$2,400 depending on origin ZIP
- **Enclosed transport**: materially more expensive (typically 40–70% premium). Worth it for collector cars; overkill for daily drivers.

While your car is in transit: budget one-way airfare plus 1–3 nights of rental-car coverage at the Raleigh end. Most brokers give delivery windows, not fixed dates.

The first 90 days, in order

NC's rule for new residents: **within 60 days** of establishing permanent residence, get an NC driver's license and title-plus-register your vehicles with NCDMV. The legal deadline is clear; the bottleneck is usually the driver-license appointment, not the plate agency.

Recommended sequence:

1. **Week 1 — bind NC auto insurance.** You can't register a vehicle without it. Gather title or lienholder documents and your residency proof (lease or mortgage + utility bill).
2. **Weeks 1–3 — driver's license appointment.** Book this as early as you can; appointments fill fast. Accepted residency documents include lease/mortgage records, utility bills, government documents, financial statements, and school records. When issued, you get a temporary paper certificate valid for 60 days while the physical card arrives.
3. **Weeks 2–6 — title and register the vehicle.** At a license plate agency or by mail. You'll pay: title fee + **3% highway-use tax** + first annual vehicle property tax + registration fees + any local wheel fee. Annual **safety inspection** is required within 90 days of registration (inspect first, then register, not the reverse).
4. **Anytime in first 60 days — voter registration.** Do this at the DMV visit; it's one form and bundles with the license work.

Common delays: the license appointment bottleneck, and missing a residency document (especially if your utility bill hasn't arrived yet — school or lease records often work as a substitute).

Healthcare handoff

Pediatricians, primary care, and specialists all have waitlists — often several months for popular practices at Duke Health, UNC Health, and WakeMed primary care networks. Start before you arrive.

- **Verify in-network status first.** Ask your employer for the specific plan + network before you start calling practices. "Duke Health" doesn't mean much; "Aetna Duke Select" does.
- **Call the practice, not the main hospital line.** Individual pediatric practices set their own wait times; calling the health-system switchboard gets you a generic list.
- **Pediatric dental and orthodontics have the longest waits** — 6+ months for some popular practices. Get on those lists the same week you get on the pediatrician list.

Childcare waitlists

The single most time-sensitive thing you can do from out of state: **get on daycare and preschool waitlists the moment you sign a lease or go under contract.** Popular programs have **12+ month waits**. Nonrefundable waitlist fees are normal; $50–$200 per program. Get on 3–5 lists, not one.

Chapter 7 — Cultural Infrastructure

One of the things that makes the Triangle feel more like home than people expect is the density of international markets, cultural events, and community organizations. This isn't a tourism section — it's a practical map of where to find the food, festivals, and weekend-community life that makes a region feel lived-in.

International and specialty grocery

International grocery isn't a special-occasion errand in the Triangle — it's a normal weekly run. The most established names:

- **Grand Asia Market (Raleigh)** — 30,000 sq ft, bakery and restaurant on-site. The canonical East and Southeast Asian grocery in the region.
- **H Mart Cary** — Korean-forward pan-Asian grocery; large fresh section and a food court.
- **Li Ming's Global Market (Durham)** — pan-Asian grocery with a food court.
- **Golden Hex (Cary)** — European and Mediterranean groceries; the deepest Slavic selection in the region.
- **Around the World Market (Raleigh)** — Indian and South Asian staples.
- **Compare Foods / Super Compare** — Latin-American-forward grocery chain with multiple Triangle locations.
- **Patel Brothers** — South Asian grocery (large regional chain).

NC State's international-services office maintains a longer specialty-grocery list covering Indian, Korean, Japanese, Middle Eastern, Latin American, and European stores across the region — useful as a broader reference.

Annual festivals and cultural events

The Triangle's cultural calendar is a steady civic rhythm, not a handful of one-off events. Official 2026 dates posted so far:

- **Bimbé Cultural Arts Festival** — May 16, 2026
- **La Fiesta del Pueblo** — September 20, 2026
- **Downtown Cary Park Diwali Celebration** — October 26, 2026
- **NC Chinese Lantern Festival** — returning November 2026 at Koka Booth Amphitheatre
- **Hum Sub** — Holi, Diwali, and other South Asian community programming year-round

Recurring fixtures worth planning around: the **International Festival of Raleigh** (fall), the **African American Cultural Festival** of Raleigh & Wake County, **Hopscotch Music Festival** (Raleigh, September), **IBMA World of Bluegrass** (late September/early October), and the **Durham Bulls** baseball season April through September.

Tech community and networking

The 2026 meetup and event mix is wide enough to let a transplant test several different "on-ramps" in a single month.

Recurring meetups:

- **Triangle Developers** — general software engineering
- **All Things Open RTP meetup** — open-source and general tech
- **Triangle Cybersecurity / TriCyTuesdays** — monthly security meetup
- **Triangle Tech Net** — IT and career networking
- **ProductTank Triangle** — product management
- **All Things AI Live** — monthly AI meetup
- **AI Tinkerers Raleigh** — builder-focused demos

2026 conferences already on the calendar:

- **TechConnect World** — March 10–12, Raleigh
- **All Things AI** — March 22–24, downtown Durham
- **Venture Connect** — March 24–25, DPAC
- **TechFest North Carolina** — May 13–14
- All Things Open — October 19–20, RTP (the region's anchor open-source conference)

NC TECH runs a steady cadence of Triangle-facing programming (Government Vendor Network, Young Tech Professionals events, annual NC TECH Awards). **RIoT's State of the Region** is another reliable regional convening.

Coworking — useful for scouting

Coworking spaces double as relocation scouting tools: they let you experience the Triangle as a working adult, not a tourist.

- Frontier RTP — free public coworking on an RTP campus; regular entrepreneur events.
- Raleigh Founded — multiple Raleigh locations, flexible office plans.
- American Underground — downtown Durham startup hub with member events.
- Innovate Carolina Junction — downtown Chapel Hill; free coworking day the first Friday of each month.
- **The Loading Dock** — Raleigh and Wake Forest locations.
- **Switchyards Durham** — 24/7 neighborhood-work-club near downtown Durham.

One midday coworking trial plus one evening meetup during your scouting trip will tell you a lot.

Places of worship and community organizations

The Triangle has durable institutions across most major traditions. A non-exhaustive list of examples newcomers commonly reference:

- **Islamic Association of Raleigh** — masjid, school, and community gathering place for the Triangle
- **Beth Meyer Synagogue** (Raleigh, Conservative) and **Judea Reform Congregation** (Durham)
- **Sri Venkateswara Temple of North Carolina** (Cary)
- **Sikh Gurudwara of North Carolina** (Durham)
- **Kadampa Center** (Raleigh, Buddhist)
- **St. Barbara Greek Orthodox Church** (serving Durham and Chapel Hill)

Most of these have worship schedules, classes, tours, or community programming listed on their sites. If your family's tradition isn't listed above, it's almost certainly represented — a quick local search before you move will usually turn up active options.

Chapter 8 — Seasonal Survival Guide

Spring: the pollen reckoning

Tree pollen starts as early as **February**, per NC State Extension, and peaks through **mid-April** before grass pollen takes over through May. The visible yellow-green dust is mostly pine pollen — annoying and aesthetic but not the main allergy culprit. The real offenders are smaller, invisible pollens from **oak, hickory, and other hardwoods**, which peak at the same time.

If anyone in your family has seasonal allergies, get set up *before* you arrive: lined up antihistamine, better HVAC filtration (MERV 11 or higher), and a car-wash habit. The NC Department of Environmental Quality publishes daily pollen monitoring during the season; the State Climate Office publishes seasonal summaries.

Summer: humidity and storms

NOAA climate normals at Raleigh-Durham show average highs climbing from **about 87°F by mid-June to 90°F/70°F by mid-July**. The NC State Climate Office recorded Raleigh's record July 2025 average **dew point of 69.8°F** — which is the number that actually describes why summer feels the way it does. High-70s dew points during heat waves are not unusual.

Hurricane season officially runs June 1 through November 30, peaking **mid-August through late October**. The Triangle sits roughly 2.5 hours inland, so the main risks aren't coastal storm surge — they're:

- Heavy rain and inland flooding
- Tornadoes spawned from tropical bands
- Damaging wind and extended power outages

Modern example: **Tropical Storm Chantal (July 2025)** brought serious inland flooding and tornadoes through central NC well away from the coast. Historic examples include **Florence (2018)** and **Fran (1996)**. A whole-house generator is overkill for most families; a portable generator or battery station is a reasonable buy.

Fall: the payoff

October and November are the months that sell the region. Cool mornings, warm afternoons, long golden light, football Saturdays. This is when you'll be glad you moved.

Winter: ice, not snow

Triangle winters are mild by most standards — highs often in the 50s — punctuated by occasional ice storms that shut down the region for 24–72 hours. The problem isn't ice *volume*; it's that the infrastructure isn't built for it, so trucks don't run, power goes out, and schools close on a forecast.

The State Climate Office's case studies document severe Piedmont ice storms across recent decades, and the **January 2026 winter event** prompted statewide warnings about sleet, freezing rain, power outages, and black ice. NCDOT's guidance is blunt: black ice is hard to predict, and the safest choice is often just staying off the roads.

Mental model: less snow volume than the Northeast, more disruption per inch. Tree damage and scattered power loss matter more than accumulation totals. A reasonable winter kit: battery power bank, headlamps, a few gallons of water, non-perishable food for 72 hours, and warm layers. A portable generator handles the 1-in-3-year ice event; full home backup is overkill.

Home and yard implications

Your climate-adjusted home shopping checklist, informed by how the region actually behaves:

- **HVAC capacity and sizing.** EPA recommends indoor humidity **between 30% and 50%** (below 60% in any case). DOE warns that *oversized* HVAC equipment can actually make humidity worse — bigger isn't better. High-efficiency heat pumps dehumidify better than standard central AC. Ask about unit age and sizing; the unit will run hard June through September.
- **Crawlspace and drainage.** Check for moisture, standing water, and adequate vapor barrier before you buy. Mold and mildew are a thing in this climate.
- **Duct condition.** Leaky or poorly sealed ducts are a common source of humidity problems in older Triangle homes.
- **Yard expectations.** Most family homes have lawns; most HOAs have standards. **Tall fescue** is common in the Piedmont but struggles in hot, wet summers and often needs reseeding.

Bermudagrass thrives in summer but demands frequent low mowing. Decide how much yard you actually want to maintain before you buy half an acre.

- **Standing water attracts mosquitoes.** Clogged gutters, neglected birdbaths, and poorly graded yards become mosquito breeding grounds by June. Budget 10 minutes a week for the audit.

What to pack (and what to replace)

Transplants from cooler/drier climates usually over-pack winter gear and under-pack for humidity. The practical mix:

- **Keep:** rain gear, sun hats, power banks, breathable summer clothes, a couple of genuine cold-weather layers (useful 2–3 times per winter)
- **Replace the idea of:** a deep-winter wardrobe, snow equipment
- **Buy after you arrive:** a lawnmower and trimmer, screened-porch furniture, good HVAC filters, humidity management (dehumidifier if crawlspace moisture is an issue)

Next Steps — Working With Nick

If this guide has been useful, here's the honest version of what comes next.

Most families read a guide like this and do one of three things:

1. **Decide the Triangle isn't right.** That's a good outcome. The whole point of Chapter 1 is to help you reach that conclusion before you burn a plane ticket.
2. **Keep researching on their own.** Also fine. The chapters above are designed to stand on their own, and the live cost-of-living calculator on relocateraleigh.com handles the interactive math for any U.S. starting point.
3. **Want a local who has actually made this move guiding them through it.** That's where Nick comes in.

How Nick helps

Nick is a licensed North Carolina Realtor® and a senior IT professional in the Triangle. He moved here with his own family, navigated the same school-timing, commute, and cost tradeoffs this guide talks about, and now works with other families doing the same thing. What that typically looks like in practice:

- **An honest first call.** Not a pitch — a 30-minute conversation about where you are in the process, what you're optimizing for, and whether the Triangle actually fits. If it doesn't, he'll tell you.
- **Neighborhood and school guidance that matches your family**, not the commission structure. The matrix in Chapter 2 is a starting point; the real work is figuring out which of those nine

neighborhoods fits *your* kids, your commute, and your budget.

- **Scouting trip support**, including the "which addresses should we actually look at" pre-work that makes a 3-day trip productive.
- **The purchase itself** if you decide to buy here, as your buyer's agent.
- **Handoffs** to the movers, lenders, inspectors, pediatricians, and other professionals most families need lined up on arrival.

Nick works with families from anywhere in the U.S. moving to the Triangle for any reason — tech jobs, healthcare careers, aging parents, weather, schools, or just a calmer pace of life.

Get in touch

The simplest next step is the **Get In Touch** form on relocateraleigh.com. Tell him where you're moving from and roughly when — he'll reply within a day or two and suggest a time to talk.

If you'd rather email directly: **team@relocateraleigh.com**.

No pressure, no sales funnel. Just a local who's been through the move.

Appendix A — Scouting Trip Checklist

A printable one-page version of Chapter 3. Print it, bring it, fill it out in the car between neighborhood visits.

Before the trip

- [ ] Pick 3–4 candidate addresses (not just neighborhoods)
- [ ] Run each address through the WCPSS base-school lookup, DPS locator, or CHCCS maps as applicable
- [ ] Book flights into RDU
- [ ] Reserve a rental car (not a rideshare week)
- [ ] Book lodging near one of your candidate areas, not downtown (unless downtown is a candidate)
- [ ] Download DriveNC for real-time traffic

What to pack

- [ ] Comfortable walking shoes (you'll park and walk more than you expect)
- [ ] Layers (April mornings and November evenings can flip cool)
- [ ] Umbrella or rain shell (afternoon thunderstorms in summer)

- [ ] Antihistamine if you scout in March/April
- [ ] Phone charger and car mount
- [ ] This checklist, plus a pen
- [ ] A printed list of your candidate addresses and their assigned schools

What to notice (per neighborhood)

- [ ] Street condition, sidewalks, shade, noise level
- [ ] Who's outside on a weekday — dog walkers, kids on bikes, nobody
- [ ] The strip center within 5 minutes — does it look like a place you'd actually use?
- [ ] The grocery store — who shops there, what's in the produce section
- [ ] The school drop-off traffic pattern if timing allows
- [ ] The commute to RTP at actual rush hour (7:30–9 AM or 5–6:30 PM)

Questions to ask a buyer's agent

- [ ] What is the full combined property-tax rate at this exact address (county + municipal + any fire district or special district)?
- [ ] What are the HOA fees and what do they include?
- [ ] Has the assigned base school changed in the last 3 years? Is it under any pending enrollment-planning review?
- [ ] What's the crawlspace / basement moisture history?
- [ ] How old is the HVAC, and is it properly sized?
- [ ] What's the current market competitive dynamic for this submarket — are offers going above list?

Questions to ask at a school tour

- [ ] What's the student-to-teacher ratio at each grade level?
- [ ] How does the transfer policy work if my address changes during the school year?
- [ ] What language and heritage-culture programs are available?
- [ ] How does the school handle new students mid-year?
- [ ] If it's a year-round calendar school, what's the track assignment process?

Neighborhood scoring rubric

Fill this in after each neighborhood visit. Score each category 1–5.

Category	Neighborhood 1	Neighborhood 2	Neighborhood 3
Commute to RTP (rush hour)			
School fit for our kids			
House price vs. our budget			
Does it feel like "home"			
Walkability / errand convenience			
Green space / outdoors access			
Match to the family we want to become			
Total			

Appendix B — First 90 Days Checklist

A printable one-page version of Chapter 6. The single most useful thing you can bring to moving week.

Before you arrive

- ☐ Get on **3–5 daycare / preschool waitlists** (if applicable) the moment you're under contract or sign a lease
- ☐ Get on **pediatrician and primary-care waitlists** — verify in-network status *first*
- ☐ Get on **pediatric dental and orthodontist** waitlists — these are often the longest
- ☐ Set up utility transfers (Duke Energy, city water/sewer, gas if applicable) for move-in day
- ☐ Arrange internet install for move-in day (2–4 week lead time is common)

Week 1 after arrival

- ☐ Bind North Carolina auto insurance
- ☐ Gather residency documents: lease or mortgage, utility bill, any government/school/financial records
- ☐ Book your NCDMV driver's-license appointment (the bottleneck — do this first)
- ☐ Begin vehicle title and registration paperwork

Weeks 1–3

- [ ] Complete driver's license appointment (you'll get a temporary paper certificate valid 60 days)
- [ ] Update insurance company with the NC license number when issued

Weeks 2–6

- [ ] Get annual vehicle safety inspection (required before registration)
- [ ] Title and register your vehicle(s) at a plate agency or by mail. Budget for:
  - [ ] Title fee
  - [ ] 3% highway-use tax
  - [ ] First annual vehicle property tax
  - [ ] Registration fees
  - [ ] Municipal vehicle fee ($30 in Raleigh and Cary; varies by municipality)
- [ ] Register to vote (can be done at the DMV visit)
- [ ] Submit school enrollment paperwork
- [ ] Meet the pediatrician / primary care doctor when your waitlist comes up

Ongoing first 90 days

- [ ] Find a dentist, orthodontist, optometrist (in-network through your insurance)
- [ ] Set up a local bank if you're moving from outside the Southeast
- [ ] Update mailing address with IRS, employer, financial institutions, subscription services
- [ ] Find a primary neighborhood grocery, coffee shop, pharmacy
- [ ] Sign up for one neighborhood/community thing (church, sports league, meetup, HOA committee) — this is what makes a place start to feel like home

Legal deadline reminder

You have 60 days from establishing NC residency to have an NC driver's license and NC-registered vehicles. The appointment bottleneck is real; don't leave this to week 8.

Appendix C — Cost Comparison Worksheet

The calculator on relocateraleigh.com does this interactively. This is the PDF-friendly version for running your own numbers on paper.

Fill in the left column for your current metro; the right column shows Triangle ranges or links back to the relevant chapter.

Housing

Line item	Where you are now	Triangle (annual)
Purchase price (home you'd actually buy)	$	See Ch 2
Property tax rate (combined county + municipal)	%	~0.86–1.05% depending on location — see Ch 5
Estimated annual property tax	$	$
HOA fees (annual)	$	$200–$1,200+ typical
Home insurance (annual)	$	$

Income tax

Leaving from	Their top state rate	NC flat rate
Your current state	%	**3.99%**

Run a back-of-envelope: `(old_rate − 3.99%) × household income = your annual tax delta`. For a Bay Area household at $300K, that's roughly **$28K/year** saved. For a Seattle household, it's a $12K/year increase — offset (usually more than offset) by housing.

Vehicle costs (annual, Triangle)

Line item	Estimate
3% highway-use tax (one-time, on title transfer)	3% × vehicle value
Annual vehicle property tax	$300–$600 per vehicle
Municipal vehicle fee	$30 in Raleigh / Cary; varies
Safety inspection	~$30/year per vehicle

Childcare (annual, Triangle planning estimate)

Situation	Typical Triangle range
Full-time daycare (infant)	$18,000–$28,000
Full-time daycare (toddler/preschool)	$14,000–$22,000
After-school care (school-aged)	$4,000–$9,000

Verify against programs on your specific waitlist — these vary widely by program and neighborhood.

Commute

Line item	Where you are now	Triangle
Daily round-trip miles		
Toll cost (NC-540)	N/A	~$3–$6/day if used
Transit pass	$	Often $0 (most commute by car)

Utilities (monthly, Triangle)

Line item	Typical range
Electricity (summer peak)	$250–$400+
Electricity (winter)	$120–$200
Water / sewer	$60–$120
Internet (1 gbps)	$60–$90
Natural gas (if applicable)	$40–$120 seasonal

The bottom line

Add annual housing + tax + childcare + commute + utilities for each column. The delta is your "what you'd actually save (or spend) per year" number. Most families moving from a Tier-1 high-COL metro see a $40K–$120K+ annual gross improvement; most moving from a moderate metro see a smaller but still positive delta once the full picture is factored in.

For any 50-state comparison with live numbers, use the calculator on relocateraleigh.com.